Nobulous Apprenticeship Program (NAP)

A prestigious opportunity. Terms and conditions apply.

One Apprentice, three Time Slots a day, and a workload that does not care how tired you are. Earn Credits across four subjects, survive the things that go wrong, and pass a Final Exam assembled from the subjects you actually studied.

COMPONENTS

- 3 double-sided Apprentice cards — 6 Apprentices, one to a side
- 26 Task cards
- 6 Opportunity cards
- 6 Setback cards
- 3 Time Slot cards — Morning, Afternoon, Evening
- 3 Following in Nobulous' Footsteps (FINF) cards
- 12 Final Exam cards
- **From 20 Strong:** the 17 unit dice — 4 Purple, 4 Blue, 4 Green, 4 Yellow, 1 Red
- **From 20 Strong:** the 3 stat dice — HP, STR, REC — and the Chip

SETUP

1. Choose an Apprentice. All six begin at **2 HP / 2 STR / 2 REC**; they differ only in abilities.
2. Choose a difficulty level: **Easy 5**, **Standard 6**, **Hard 7** or **Nobulous 8** Credits.
3. Shuffle in **your difficulty's Setbacks** — 3, 3, 4 or 5 of the 6, from the *Difficulty* table below — with the 26 Tasks and 6 Opportunities to form the **Assignment deck**. Return the unused Setbacks to the box.
4. Choose a FINF setting: **Increase 1–3** or **Reduce 1–3**. Standard is **Reduce 1**. Take that many of the 3 FINF cards at random; return the rest to the box. See *Following in Nobulous' Footsteps* below for what each direction does.
5. Set aside the 12 Final Exams. You will build the exam pool later.
6. Place the color selection side of the chip next to the Morning Time Slot card.

OBJECT OF THE GAME

The Final Exam comes either way. You sit for it when you reach your **Credit goal** — see the difficulty table — or when the Assignment deck runs out, whichever happens first. Credits are earned by completing Credit Tasks; not satisfying the Credit goal does not end the game, it costs you dice (see *Leaving the apprenticeship*). Regardless, you must survive three exams with at least 1 Health remaining to win.

FOLLOWING IN NOBULOUS' FOOTSTEPS (FINF)

FINF is a second dial, independent of the difficulty level, that works in two directions. Choose one setting before you start and keep it for the whole game.

Increase — 1 / 2 / 3

Take that many FINF cards at random and **shuffle them into the Assignment deck**. When one is drawn, **add an Assignment from the top of the deck to the corresponding Time Slot** then discard the FINF card. Ignore Skulls on Assignments added by FINF, and never exceed 4 Assignments in one row.

Reduce — 1 / 2 / 3

Take that many FINF cards at random, flip them face-up, and set them to the side. Each can be used once. You may **remove a non-Final-Exam card from the active Time Slot** only if you hold the FINF card numbered for that slot: spend it, exhaust all dice stored on the removed card, and turn the FINF card face-down. Holding FINF 2, for example, lets you remove one card during an Afternoon.

FINF cards are not used during the Final Exam, in either direction.

DIFFICULTY

Difficulty can be adjusted in two principal ways: the **Credit goal** you must reach before the Final Exam, and the number of **Setbacks** shuffled into the Assignment deck. Choose a level before you start the game.

LEVEL	CREDIT GOAL	SETBACKS
Easy	5 Credits	3
Standard	**6 Credits**	**3**
Hard	7 Credits	4
Nobulous	8 Credits	5

SUBJECT ICONS

Task and Final Exam cards use these icons to identify their subject. A Task with no subject icon is unmarked.

ICON	SUBJECT
	Anatomy
	Engineering
	Procedure
	Theory

HOW THE APPRENTICESHIP ENDS

Play until you **reach your Credit goal** or **the Assignment deck runs out**, then proceed to the Final Exam.

The Final Exam begins at the end of a Day, never part-way through one. Reaching your Credit goal early does not interrupt the Day: play out the Time Slots that are left, resolve the End of Day, and then set up the Final Exam. A goal reached in a Morning still requires an Afternoon and an Evening session. Completing additional goals during these additional time slots is helpful — each Credit above your goal allows you to recover another die in *Preparation* for the Final Exam.

Running out of Assignments is the exception and ends the apprenticeship immediately. With no deck there is nothing to reveal, so the remaining Time Slots cannot be played.

If your Health ever reaches 0 you lose immediately — during the apprenticeship or during the exams.

THE DAY

Each day has three Time Slots: **Morning**, **Afternoon**, **Evening**. Each slot follows these steps below. Note, REC only occurs at the end of the day. Dice can only be recovered during the day via the **Special Recovery** or from card-specific effects.

1. Perform **Special Recovery** for the color on the dial (Day 1 Morning has nothing queued, so there is none.)
2. Reveal 2 Assignments and place one into the row as your **Primary** assignment (shift unresolved cards to the right); **Discard the other Assignment.** The Primary's recovery-color dot sets the color queued for the next Time Slot.
   - If a Setback is revealed, you **must** take it. If two Setbacks are revealed, take the one with the higher Target.
   - If you take a card with one or more **Skulls**, add the corresponding number of cards from the Assignment deck to the Time Slot (if able). See the *Skulls* box below.
3. Attempt to complete Assignments with Strategy rolls.
4. Rotate or discard unresolved Assignments as described below and exhaust non-stored committed dice. Then, set the dial to the Primary's dot and advance the chip to the next Time Slot. **Do not recover again** — the dial you have just set is what the next slot will recover during step 1.

After Evening, resolve **End of Day**.

Assignments placed in a given Time Slot stay there until completed or discarded; they do not follow you into the next Time Slot. A Time Slot can hold a maximum of **4** Assignments — if the row is already full when you reveal, discard both revealed cards and take nothing. **The queued recovery color does not change** when that happens: with no Primary to set a new one, the dial stays where it is and the next Time Slot recovers on the same color again.

SPECIAL RECOVERY

Recover **all** exhausted dice of the queued recovery color.

STR in NAP

STR is the number of **Strategy rolls** available in a Time Slot; it resets for every Time Slot. **It does not cap how many Assignments you may complete.** One roll's successes can be spread across several Assignments, and cards already holding stored progress can finish alongside them. Clearing more Assignments than you have Strategy rolls is normal — it is what storing progress is *for*.

ATTEMPTING ASSIGNMENTS

- You may assign dice across as many Assignments as you like (in the active Time Slot) during a roll.
- **Required Effort:** Choose at least one Assignment — a Setback if one is present — and commit either one die matching that Assignment's color dot, Red, or at least two dice of another color. **This requirement can be waived only if no legal commitment/assignment is possible.**
- To **complete an Assignment or store progress on it**, the successes you apply must include a die matching its color dot, Red (as wild), or two successful dice of another color. After this requirement is satisfied, you may add successes for any additional committed dice to the card.

Unresolved Assignments

- Successful dice on an unresolved Assignment may be **stored as progress** instead of being exhausted.
- **At the end of the Time Slot**, every unresolved Task flips to its **Demand** side — a harsher printed effect, and often a higher Target. Flipping costs nothing by itself.
- An unresolved Opportunity rotates **180 degrees** for one final chance (during that Time Slot on the following day). **You cannot store progress on Opportunities**. If the rotated Opportunity is still incomplete at the end of the day, discard it without applying an effect or penalty.
- An Assignment that is *already* on its Demand side and still unresolved at the end of a Time Slot **inflicts its printed Demand penalty** and is then discarded. When a penalty exhausts dice, exhaust dice of that Assignment's **recovery-dot color** first; otherwise, exhaust your weakest dice.
- Once the next Time Slot begins, stored dice are locked to that Assignment and cannot be voluntarily exhausted.
- When an Assignment finally resolves, its committed and stored dice exhaust unless the card says otherwise. A Credit Task completed on its **Demand** side still counts as a completed Credit.

- Rotate every completed Task, Opportunity, or Setback **90 degrees** and leave it in its Time Slot until End of Day. Resolve its completion reward before continuing.
- Completing an Opportunity never pays out on the spot: you **keep the card as a coupon** (see *Completed Opportunities*).

Assignment types

TYPE	ROLE
Task	The only source of Credits.
Setback	Mandatory and disruptive. No Credits.
Opportunity	Optional. No Credits or penalties; rotate once for a final chance. Completing one earns a coupon.

Completed Opportunities

An Opportunity pays nothing when you complete it. Instead you **keep the card in front of you as a coupon**. It has no expiration: spend it whenever you like, on any Day, including during the Final Exam. Each is a **one-time use** — spend it, apply the effect, then discard the card.

OPPORTUNITY	SPEND IT TO…
Take an Unauthorized Break	Cancel 1 Health loss.
Raid the Supply Closet	Count one die as any color for one roll.
Borrow Better Instruments	Add 1 success to a roll.
Study Nobulous' Notes	Reduce one Assignment's remaining need by 2.
Salvage Useful Components	Add 2 successes to an Assignment, without rolling.
Practice on a Spare Brain	Count one Crit as 3 successes.

Completed opportunity rewards that add successes still obey the color rule: they can be added to a Task or Setback that already includes a legal die. You may hold any number of completed opportunities; unspent rewards score nothing at the end of the game.

> **SKULLS**
>
> Skulls resolve only on Assignments *you chose*. Ignore Skulls on cards added by another Skull, by FINF, or by a forced replacement. If a Skull would add an Assignment while the slot already holds 4, do not add a card — instead rotate the Skull-generating Assignment to its Demand side once. Further blocked Skulls do nothing.

END OF DAY

Move all completed Assignments from the Time Slots to the face-up discard pile. Reveal and discard the top card of the Assignment deck. Ignore all of its text, effects and Skulls. Then recover exhausted dice equal to your **REC**.

THE FINAL EXAM

Leaving the apprenticeship

Discard unresolved Assignments and exhaust their stored dice. If you are short of your Credit goal, exhaust 1 available die per missing Credit in the order Red, Purple, Blue, Green, Yellow, looping as needed.

Preparation

- Recover 1 exhausted die.
- Recover 1 further exhausted die per Credit *above* your Credit goal. You may not pick the same color twice.
- Perform the queued Morning special recovery.

Building the Final Exam pool

For each subject independently, randomly add the following number of Final Exam cards from that subject to the pool:

CREDITS IN SUBJECT	CARDS PLACED
0–1	1
2–3	2
4+	3

Shuffle the pool and draw **3** Final Exams.

Resolving the exams

1. Reduce the exam's base Target by 1 for each Credit you hold in that subject.
2. Roll against the modified Target, honoring the exam's printed restriction.
3. **Lose 1 Health for each success below the modified Target.** If you still have Health, you passed.
4. Perform Special Recovery using that exam card's own color dot, then resolve the next exam.

All three exams are mandatory. FINF is not used during the Final Exam. Finish all three with at least 1 Health to win NAP.

CARRYING NAP FORWARD

Only relevant if you are playing the Nobulous Research Journal (NRJ) campaign (Tier III).

NAP contributes **6 Devious Opportunities**. Any of these opportunities completed during the apprenticeship, regardless of whether the reward is used, has the potential to be retained for the *Imposter Scenario*; you may only keep a maximum of 3 Devious Opportunities (your choice). A retained card reduces a **Knowledge** Exhibit's Target in the *Imposter Scenario* by **2**.